

Undercounted at the Gate

A Season of Manual Headcounts Against the Gate Counter, and the Expansion It Fed

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The problem

Off-lead-hours expansions increasingly cite a park's automatic gate-counter tally rather than anyone who stood there and watched. Does the number a council builds a decision on hold up against a season of someone actually counting at the gate?

Research questions

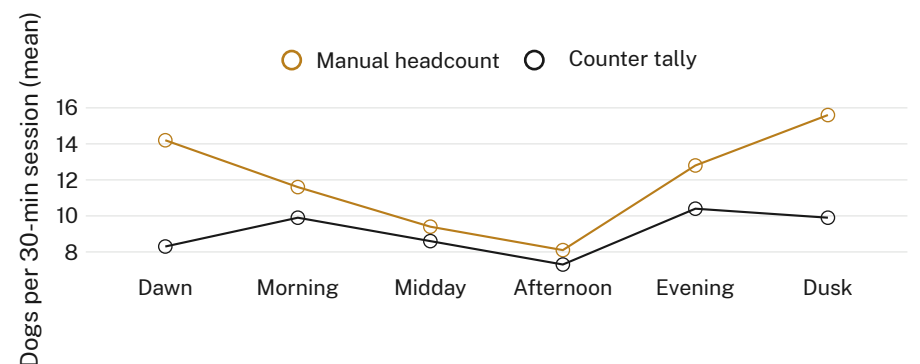
- Does an automatic gate counter's tally agree with manual headcounts across a full season?
- Does agreement vary systematically by time of day, weather, or group size?
- Which time block did the council's expansion decision actually draw on?

Study design

- 1 suburban off-lead park · infrared gate counter · 96 paired 30-min sessions over 24 weeks
- Manual counts by trained observers, stratified across six daily time blocks
- Counter firmware, sensor height, and mounting angle held constant; no mid-study recalibration

What we found

Counter-to-manual agreement is highest at midday and falls sharply at the day's edges. The expansion business case drew its headline figure from exactly the block where agreement is weakest.



Mean counter tally sits at 58% of the paired manual headcount in the dawn block, against 91% at midday, across 96 sessions logged April–September 2025; the council's off-lead-hours expansion business case cited the dawn figure.

Implications

The counter's blind spot sits precisely where off-lead demand is least visible and least contested. A tally calibrated against a still midday crowd is now the evidentiary base for a dawn-hours expansion it cannot see clearly. Next: field-validate gate counters against dawn and dusk headcounts before any further hours decision leans on them.

Selected references

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We thank the rangers of the instrumented off-lead park; headcounts logged off-lead hours only, no owner or pet identity retained.

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